

RISING STARLING

A newbie who chose a Kingfisher calendar over a Miss India contest, a model who preferred an acting course to a seamless transition as a glamazon, Deepika Padukone is a star about to be born

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

As a gangly young girl trying to study for her school exams, Deepika Padukone remembers being dreamily distracted by Mohammed Rafi songs wafting out of the loudspeakers in her father's room. Now 21-year-old, as she moves with a dancer's grace between an endorsement meeting, a media interview and a group of friends waiting patiently with coffee and conversation, the 5'8" Padukone is a work of art, dimpling prettily when faced with a question about her love life even as she opens her expressive eyes wider when asked about her next move. The picture is so perfectly poised that it is all too easy to forget the steely determination that has got her here—not here, as in the coffee shop of a suburban Mumbai hotel right next to the mansion of the superstar who is her romantic hero in one of the year's biggest films. But here, as on the cusp of one of the most anticipated Bollywood debuts this year.

It's a progress that the badminton ace Prakash Padukone's daughter has observed with care. "I've seen myself go from being on the cover of magazines, to having articles written about me," she says, sounding like an excited young girl who is seeing her dream come true. The newcomer who didn't know her angles now poses effortlessly "wherever I shine the lights," says Atul Kasbekar, mentor, photographer and founder of Bling, the talent agency that handles her work. The model who has gone from making Rs 2 lakh per fashion show a year ago to Rs 50 lakh per endorsement has two-year contracts with Maybelline, Levi's Signature and Marico's Parachute Oil, and has just signed on two more, for Rs 75 lakh each. The starling has gone from being Farah Khan's surprise choice for *Om Shanti Om* (*OSO*), one of the two films releasing on Diwali, to becoming a soon-to-be-bona fide star. "Five minutes into *OSO*, people will watch her in a song where she does everything from the cabaret to Kathak, and they will fall in love with her," says Farah.

Padukone, who stopped playing badminton in 2002 though she was a national-level player, seems to have been preparing for stardom all her life. Anila Anand, her school mate's mother, remembers hiring her as a model for a Weekender For Kids advertisement when she was 10, by which time she had enrolled in a dance academy where they taught jazz ballet and ramp walking. "After that, Deepika was very keen to do more modelling but I tried to evade her until she came to me in Class XI and said she was going to become a model with or without my help." Her mother, Ujjala—a travel agent who has now given up her job to travel with the younger daughter Anisha, all of 16, and raring to become a

golf pro—invested Rs 10,000 in a professionally photographed portfolio, and from then on, whether it was Liril or Close-Up, Padukone's radiant smile was ubiquitous on TV commercials.

It was at this time, says Anand, that her parents decided to let go. "It was not easy but they did," says Anand, and Padukone moved from Bangalore to Mumbai in 2005, dropping out of Class XI in her single-minded pursuit of a career in glamour, without a star mummy in tow. In Mumbai, she walked the ramp for designers, from Tarun Tahiliani to Rohit Bal, for not less than Rs 20,000 a show, and did the Kingfisher Calendar 2005, which is to women in the noughties what the beauty contests were to women in the 1990s. Ask her on her choice and she shrugs, "I wanted to be different." Movies were her long-term strategy and after meeting Farah, Padukone found herself being given the golden steps to success: learn acting with Anupam Kher, do a Kannada film (*Aishwarya* with Upendra) to iron out any flaws, brush up dancing skills with a Kathak course, and then turn up at 6.30 a.m. and just work

flat out. As Kasbekar says: "She doesn't go clubbing and neither does she smoke or drink." She does relax, but it's usually by being driven down to a friend's farmhouse, going home to be spoilt by her mother, or as she did last year, attending good friend Himesh Reshammiya's concerts in the UK.

"Unlike most actors," says Kher, who calls her his acting school's best brand ambassador, "Deepika listens. And she has the capacity to learn. I knew it wasn't easy for her, especially because she was well known. As a model you are told to do the minimum, as an actor you have to give each shot your maximum." She was always surrounded by good advice—her business manager, who is also a vice-president at Bling, travels with her. Bling is like a surrogate family that discusses movies, modelling and even men, while her actual family gets accustomed to the pressure of glamour. Says Farah: "Her parents came to the sets of *OSO* a couple of times and you know it was the first time they had ever seen a film shoot?"

Perhaps it is her middle-class upbringing that allows her to be enthused by the perks of earning so much so young (she has just bought herself a two-bedroom house in Bandra and is driven around in a Hyundai Accent) and yet not be too greedy. She has signed just one film after *OSO*, Nikhil Advani's *Made in China* with Akshay Kumar, and is already training in martial arts for it. She is also getting used to being what one critic called becoming a commodity consumed in checkout lines, having her love life being paraded in public in tall tabloid tales. Ask her about her friends, actors Nihar Pandya and Ranbir Kapoor, and she ducks her head with a mixture of bashfulness and bravado: "Hey, I'm only 21."

Twenty-one, yes, but beyond the hype and hope, almost a star.

She was very punctual. Add to that a great body, no hang-ups and the desire to work hard.

FARAH KHAN, DIRECTOR